

The Great Zimbabwe: Schism

An Unofficial Fan Expansion

Introduction

schism /'s(k)izəm/ (noun)

a split or division between strongly opposed sections or parties, caused by differences in opinion or belief.

Schism is a fanmade expansion for The Great Zimbabwe. Splotter Spellen was not involved in design or playtesting, and thus this expansion should not be viewed as a canonical addition to the base game.

Even though The Great Zimbabwe's base game already offers so much depth, we couldn't help but think of ways to continue exploring the edges and in-betweens of this amazing decision space.

We introduced 12 new gods to challenge the traditions of the 12 old gods – the spark of a religious schism. We also recognized that such an endeavor coming from a group other than Splotter Spellen might charmingly cause its own schism among players.

Components

- 12 god cards
- 1 god plaque
- 1 craftsman technology card
- 3 craftsman tiles

Setup

When playing with the Schism expansion, add the 12 Schism god cards in with the 12 base game god cards. Randomly draw 8 god cards to form the god pool.

Given there are 735,471 possible god pool combinations, we encourage you to explore these combinations, shuffling and redrawing the god pool until you find one that most sparks your curiosity and excitement.

Variants:

- *Schism Split*: Randomly draw 4 base game gods and 4 Schism gods to form the god pool.
- *Schism Only*: Randomly draw 8 Schism gods to form the god pool.

Schism Gods

Agwu Nsi, God of Divination (VR+5)

“When raising monuments, craftsmen you use may consume any resource type”

When the player adoring Agwu Nsi raises monuments, they may use any resource type for any craftsman.

Aja, Goddess of the Forest (VR+3)

“Once per round, place your turn order bid on this card”

During the Generosity of Kings phase, the player who adores Aja may place one of their bids on Aja's card instead of distributing it to the empire plaques. These cattle do not return to the player adoring Aja until the Revenues phase.

Aje-Shaluga, Goddess of Wealth (VR+4)

“When using your own secondary craftsmen, you pay 0 cattle for the primary ritual good”

When the player adoring Aje-Shaluga raises monuments using their own secondary craftsmen, they pay 0 cattle for the primary ritual good provided to the secondary craftsman. This effect does not apply to secondary craftsmen belonging to other players and other players still use Aje-Shaluga's secondary craftsmen as normal.

Alajire, God of Suffering (VR+2)

“All other players gain VR+5 (max 40)”

When a player chooses to adore Alajire, all other players gain VR+5. If this action would bring a player above 40 VR, they set their VR to 40 (maintaining current order). If a player at 40 VR chooses to adore a god that would lower their VR (e.g. Gu, Xango), the VR is recalculated. If, after recalculating, that player's VR would still be above 40, they may not adore that god.

Anyanwu, God of the Sun (VR+6)

“Raise a monument to Level 3”

The player who chooses to adore Anyanwu immediately raises a monument to Level 3 and scores points for the difference (6 points from Level 1, 4 points from Level 2). Choosing to adore Anyanwu does not count as a raise monuments action. This monument will be considered for revenue and may be raised again (even on the same turn the player chose to adore Anyanwu).

Ekwensu, God of Trade (VR+0)

“Other players may use up to 12 cattle from the bank to pay your craftsmen”

The player who chooses to adore Ekwensu takes the Ekwensu plaque and places 12 cattle from the bank on it. Other players may use these cattle to pay craftsmen belonging to the player who adores Ekwensu. These cattle may not be used to pay for hubs. They remain on the plaque until used and do not come off during the Revenues phase.

Ogun, God of Iron (VR+3)

“Take the Blacksmith technology card”

The player who chooses to adore Ogun takes the Blacksmith technology card and may now build Blacksmiths when taking the craftsman action.

Blacksmith: This is a unique primary craftsman that consumes two different resources in range to produce one good – a ritual knife. The Blacksmith consumes Ivory, Clay, or Wood, but not Diamonds. Each new Blacksmith requires 2 different, unused resources (as opposed to the usual 1). Each Blacksmith is worth 1 point and costs 2 cattle to build.

Ovia, God of Harmony (VR+4)

“The first cattle you would pay to any craftsman is paid to this card instead”

The player who adores Ovia places the first cattle that would be paid to any craftsman onto Ovia’s card. This includes cattle paid from Ekwensu’s plaque.

Oya, God of Rebirth (VR+6)

“After raising monuments, place a monument”

After raising monuments, the player adoring Oya may place a new monument following normal placement rules. This placement may be modified by Nomads.

Simbi, Who Flows Like Water (VR+2)

“You travel over orthogonally adjacent craftsmen and resources as one area”

The player who adores Simbi travels over orthogonally adjacent craftsmen and resources as one area – similar to how players travel over water. This includes resources placed using the Shaman.

Tiurakh, God of Property (VR+7)

“Monuments Level 2 or higher require 1 fewer ritual good to be raised”

When raising any monument that is Level 2 or higher, the player adoring Tiurakh pays one fewer ritual good.

Yemoja, Mother of Humanity (VR+4)

“You may raise other players’ monuments and score points for the upgrade”

The player adoring Yemoja may raise other players’ monuments. When doing so, place a disc on top of another player’s monument and score points for the upgrade (2 points for Level 2, 4 points for Level 3, 6 points for Level 4, and 8 points for Level 5). The monument still belongs to the player who placed it. They will consider that monument’s full height for revenue and may raise it, but subtract points for any levels added by the player adoring Yemoja.

Example: Red adores Engai and Green adores Yemoja. Red has a Level 4 monument with discs in this order (bottom to top) Red-Red-Green-Red. This monument is worth 9 points for Red and 4 points for Green.

Development notes

In May 2022, our playgroup started toying with ideas about how to introduce new interactions to Zimbabwe and challenge existing play patterns. What we initially thought would be just a fun weekend of brainstorming ended up turning into a 3 year project.

Over the course of Schism’s development, we realized just how much Splotter got right, creating rich interactions from a limited set of simple powers. Though eventually we realized there was a lot we could offer to create more entanglement while also providing tools for players to express themselves in creative ways.

We found that Zimbabwe is such a resilient, interconnected system that most powers you would immediately think are broken can actually be managed by a table of thoughtful players. And ultimately, the final VR on any card does not matter as much as creating an ability that is fascinating to both play as and against.